Hamden Green Corps

Young adults growing food, restoring parks, and building careers

STATUS	501(c)(3) public charity, Connecticut
FOUNDED	2019
BASED IN	Hamden, CT (greenhouse and lot leased from the town)
SERVES	Young adults ages 18–24 from Hamden and New Haven who are out of school and out of work
ANNUAL BUDGET	About $380,000
STAFF	Director, 2 crew leaders, part-time career counselor, farm manager
VOLUNTEERS	About 30 (gardeners, park clean-up partners)
REACH	24 paid crew members per year in two cohorts; 1,200 lbs of produce donated

MISSION

Hamden Green Corps gives young adults paid, hands-on environmental work and the skills and connections to launch careers, while making our neighborhoods greener.

OUR STORY

A park ranger and a youth pastor noticed the same young men hanging around a neglected park every day and asked them to help clean it up for pay. That summer job became a six-month paid program with training in landscaping, urban farming, and tree care.

WHO WE SERVE

Young adults who have left high school or recently aged out of foster care, some with court involvement. Most have little work history. Many are parents.

PROGRAMS

Crew Season (6 months, paid)
Crews of 12 work 30 hours a week: park restoration, tree planting, and running the farm and greenhouse.

Skills and Credentials
One day a week of training: OSHA safety, pesticide applicator basics, a driver's license prep course, and financial coaching.

Career Bridge
A career counselor helps each member plan next steps and connects them with landscaping companies, the town public works department, and community colleges.

HOW WE'RE FUNDED

A workforce development board grant (40%), the town of Hamden (20%), environmental and youth foundations (30%), and produce and landscaping services sold (10%).

WHAT WE TRACK TODAY

The workforce grant requires enrollment, completion, credentials earned, and job placement at exit and 90 days later. Crew leaders track daily attendance for payroll. Trees planted and pounds of produce are counted.

WHAT WE'RE WRESTLING WITH

The 90-day follow-up is hard because young people change numbers often. Leaders want to capture growth in reliability, teamwork, and hope, which they see every day but can't put in a report.

A MOMENT FROM OUR WORK

A crew member who missed most of his first two weeks became the most reliable person on the tree crew by month three. He was hired by a regional landscaping company and came back to teach the next cohort how to run the chipper safely. (Details changed to protect privacy.)